

1990 ONWARDS

MINIMAL AND CONCEPTUAL

In the wake of 1980s power dressing – which emphasized clingy styles, bold colour, exaggerated silhouettes, and embellishment – consumers in the early 1990s seemed to tire of fashion, and the industry struggled to lure them. New notions of anti-fashion emerged, with designers paring down the look and using a plainer colour palette – the Japanese avant-garde designers had already made all-black acceptable during the 1980s. It was a different way of dressing and it appealed to women with professional jobs and busy working lives. It was a time too for deconstructivist designers like Martin Margiela and Ann Demeulemeester in Belgium, and Hussein Chalayan in England – all of whom took an intellectual approach to fashion, stripping clothes back to first principles as part of their design aesthetic.

1997



Ultimate neutral US designer Calvin Klein varies his collections subtly each season, often sticking to a colour palette of grey, beige, and black. His 1997 Spring/Summer collection made grey fashionable with luxurious fabrics and shift-like dresses, paired with bare legs.



2011

Subversive style Belgian designer Martin Margiela reinvented the classic trench coat in his Spring/Summer 2011 collection. The fabric is stretched over a two-dimensional rectangular frame to completely obscure the body beneath.

2000



Futuristic jumpsuit The millennium was on Austrian Helmut Lang's mind when he created this take on a spacesuit for his 1999 Autumn/Winter collection. The silk organza is layered over easy-give cotton and silk jersey to beautiful effect.



Experimental reduction In Hussein Chalayan's 2000 Autumn/Winter collection the designer pushed the boundaries of everyday dress. In this example he merged fashion and furniture by morphing a coffee table into a skirt.